UNIT 12 WORK ETHICS

Structure

12.0 Objectives
12.1 Warm Up
12.2 Reading Comprehension: Characteristics of Work Ethics
12.3 Vocabulary: Positive Qualities
12.4 Listening: Case History
12.5 Speaking: A Short Welcome Speech
12.6 Grammar: Verbal Phrases, Modals
12.7 Writing: Filling up an Inventory of Occupational Work Ethics
12.8 Let Us Sum Up
12.9 Answers

12.0 OBJECTIVES

This unit will help you to:

- Understand what work ethics is
- Develop the right attitude towards your work
- Develop vocabulary related to work ethics
- Understand the main points of a case study in work ethics
- Develop the ability to welcome new recruits and describe the behaviour expected of them
- Learn and practise language structures that are related to work ethics
- Be able to complete an inventory on work ethics

12.1 WARM UP

You have been appointed in a company or organization, and you are going to join the new workplace soon. You have the right qualifications and the right experience. But there is something more you need to have in order to stay on in the job and get promotions.

Think of the qualities you need to have and write them here.

.....

.....

12.2 READING COMPREHENSION: CHARACTERISTICS OF WORK ETHICS

Definition

A simple definition of 'ethics' would be a set of moral principles. The word derives from the Greek concept of 'ethos', which means 'the characteristic spirit

or attitudes of a community, people or system'. Work ethics would thus mean morality at work.

Work ethics is a universal norm, which makes us feel personally accountable and responsible for the work that we do. Basically, work ethics is usually associated with people who work hard and do a good job.

We can summarize the characteristics of work ethics under three major heads — *interpersonal skills, initiative,* and *being dependable*.

Interpersonal Skills

Interpersonal skills include our habits, attitudes, manners, appearance, and behaviour we use around other people. This affects how we get along with other people. Our interpersonal skills begin to develop early in our lives. Our family, friends and our observation of our immediate world influence our attitudes and interpersonal skills. Television and movies also have a role to play in shaping our interpersonal skills. Some of the interpersonal skills are also inherited as our appearance and our genes largely influence our personalities.

In order to improve our interpersonal skills we need to know how people look at us. We may have habits or actions that we are unaware of but which may not be appropriate. Once we become aware of them, we can make a conscious effort to change and this would positively influence our relationship with people.

As adults we have the responsibility of improving our own interpersonal skills because these greatly influence our opportunities and success. This is because people make judgments about one another based on their relationships and interpersonal skills.

Initiative

Initiative is a very important characteristic in modern times. It means the ability to act or take charge before others do. Direct supervision is often not a feature of the modern workplace. Without initiative, we may delay things and miss opportunities, which can cause problems for us. And if our performance is poor, we may lose our job and may not get another chance to prove our worth.

This ability is most important for those who work out of a home office or have a small business. Initiative helps in growing your own business by understanding what factors, risks, decisions and options are good for your own business. It reduces your dependence on others, who may not value your business the same way you do. Lack of initiative may lead to losses or reduced success.

Drive and effort are both components of initiative. Even if we are gifted, unless we work harder, longer and more efficiently than others we will never be the best. The amount of drive and effort we put forth in any of our professional or even leisure activities like sports makes the difference between average performance and high performance. In order to excel, we need to have the right attitude, skill and the initiative to perform better than the others or better than before.

Being dependable

Being dependable is a highly valued quality in the modern workplace. This concept includes honesty, reliability, and being on time. People who are not dependable can cause extra expenditure, emergencies and wastage of time, not take initiative, and not utilize resources well. Sometimes lack of dependability can have serious consequences like losses of different kinds, even loss of life.

When asked to list the most important skills and characteristics they look for while hiring new employees, many employers have listed good communication skills, positive attitude, and the ability to be dependable, punctual, and responsible. In addition to these characteristics we also need some personal characteristics, which include dressing properly, being polite, and displaying self-confidence.

Check Your Progress 1

Now answer these questions:

1) i) How would you describe 'work ethics'?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

ii) Which kind of employee would you say has good work ethics?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

iii) Which are the three major characteristics of work ethics?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

iv) Does our family or environment influence our interpersonal skills? How?

.....

.....

.....

.....

v) Why do you think interpersonal skills are important at the place of work?

.....

.....

.....

.....

vi) How can we improve our interpersonal skills?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

vii) Do we have direct supervision in the modern workplace? What do we need to have in the absence of direct supervision?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

viii) Is being gifted enough for a person to perform well and excel in his / her field? Why/why not?

.....

.....

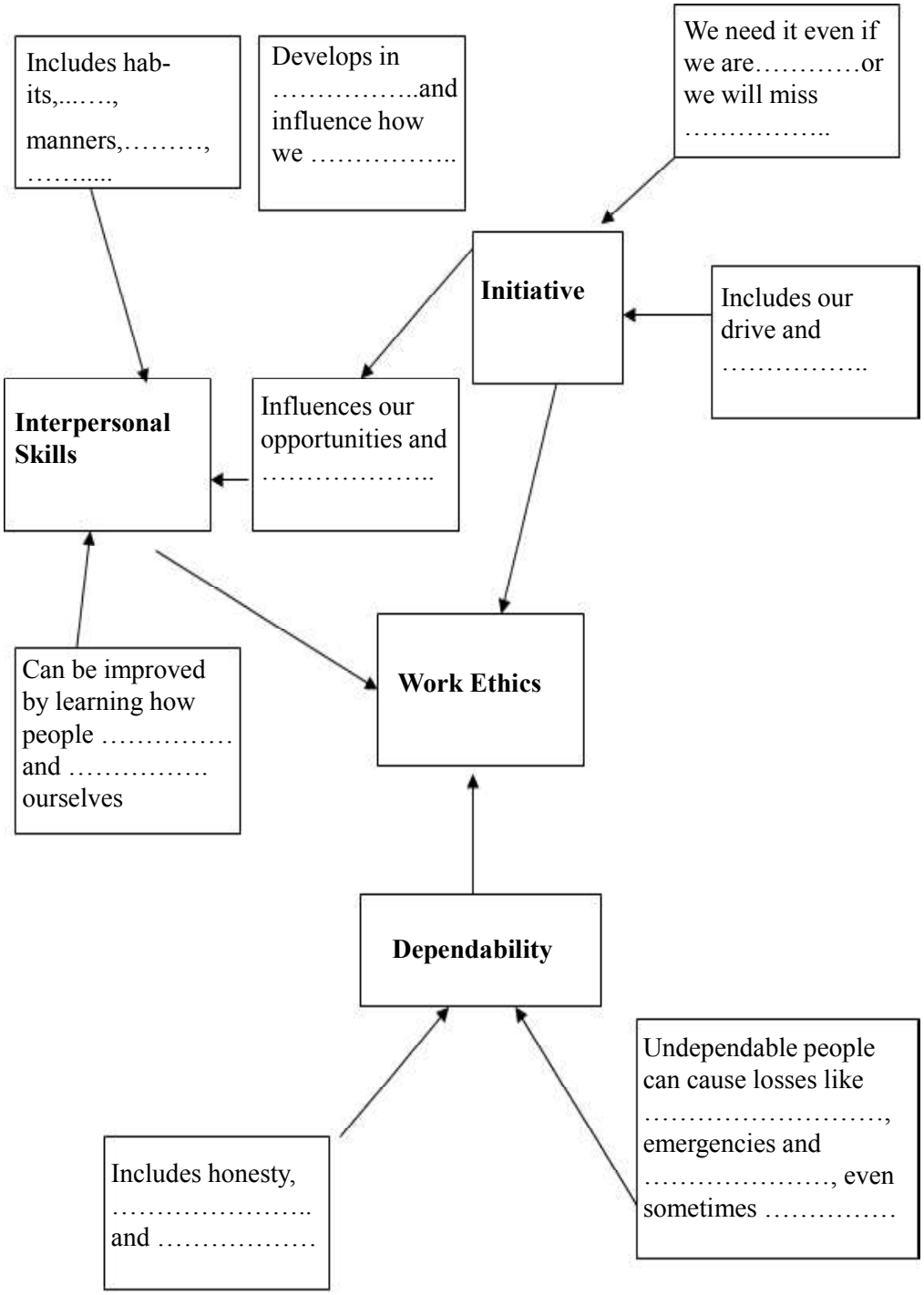
.....

.....

.....

.....

2. Complete the web chart about 'Work Ethics'.



12.3 VOCABULARY: POSITIVE QUALITIES

Check Your Progress 2

Given below are some good work habits of some people. Match them with the words in the box.

self-confidence	hard work and effort	punctuality and regularity
suitable appearance	good interpersonal skills	right attitude
initiative	dependable	

i) Rama gets on well with the others in her office. ……..

ii) You can give Tamanna any work and you can rest assured that it will be done.……

iii) Sameer takes a lot of interest to take on interesting projects and work on them. No one needs to tell him what to do next. ……

iv) Saloni always comes on time. She is never missing from office. …….

v) Bob always tries to listen to the other person's point of view. Then he gently makes his point……

vi) Pavan may not be very bright but he works hard and sincerely at whatever job he has at hand. ……..

vii) Ajmal comes very decently and smartly dressed to office. He looks so prim and proper……..

viii) We all like the way Tasleen carries herself and interacts with people. She surely makes an impression. ……

12.4 LISTENING: CASE HISTORY

Listen to this recording by a management consultant and answer these questions by ticking the right option.

Check Your Progress 3

Complete the sentences using the right option.

i) Organizational ethics falls between two things. They are ……

- law and personal abilities
- law and personal beliefs
- law and technology

ii) People in the corporate world need to ……..

- work towards individual goals of their own.
- work together towards goals different from the management.
- work towards a common goal which benefits all.

iii) Code of conduct is actually…….

- the behaviour that is prohibited.
- the behaviour that is favoured.
- the behaviour that is favoured or prohibited.

iv) Trust, loyalty and commitment are……..

- new values.
- traditional values.
- exceptional values.

12.5 SPEAKING: A SHORT WELCOME SPEECH

Check Your Progress 4

Imagine you are the team leader of a unit. A new recruit has joined your team. Introduce the person to the others and welcome the new recruit. Your speech

should help the new person feel comfortable and reassured in the new workplace.

Here are some hints:

- Greetings and expressing why you are gathered there
- New recruit's name and previous experience/position
- A few words in appreciation of the new recruit saying how valuable he/she will be to the organization
- Welcoming the new recruit
- Putting the recruit under someone's charge
- Offering to be available and ready to help in case of need
- Expressing hope in the growth of the company or unit with a new hand with diverse experience.

Write your speech here.

.....

.....

Now play the role of the team leader in turns in small groups.

12.6 GRAMMAR: VERBAL PHRASES, MODALS

You have learnt the use of some modals in your previous units. Now look at these sentences.

1) I think you **should** inform Mr. Faisal about this new development. (It is inappropriate not to inform Mr. Faisal, not doing it would not be right.)
2) You **must** check every piece of the consignment before shipping it. (It is necessary to check every piece so that no defective piece is shipped by mistake.)
3) Everyone **needs** to be computer literate nowadays. (Without being computer literate, work may be difficult.)
4) You **ought** not to use office stationary or telephone for personal purposes.
5) **Should** you require any more information, you can give me a call anytime between 9 and 6.

The words 'should', 'must', 'need' and 'ought' are **modals**.

1) We use 'should' to show what is appropriate especially when criticizing somebody's actions. It is also used for asking or giving advice. It is also used to refer to a possible event as in sentence 5.
2) 'Must' is used to say that something is necessary or important - sometimes involving rules or law.
3) The modals 'need' and 'need not' are used to state that something is/was necessary or not necessary.
4) We use 'ought to' to say what the right thing to do is. It is also used to say what you advise or recommend.

Check Your Progress 5

Complete the sentences given below using appropriate modals.

should must need ought to/ought not to

i) ……. I carry my certificates for the first informal meeting?

I think you……. You never know they may like you and would like to know more about you.

ii) We ……be hasty in coming to conclusions about people.

iii) Employees …….be at their work stations by 9 o'clock.

iv) I think this matter is serious. You ……report it to the Director immediately.

v) ……..he want to see last month's account he can access this file from my folder.

vi) You …….to get an identity card or a pass made as soon as possible. The gateman will not let you in without it.

vii) I think you ……stop worrying and concentrate on your new project.

viii) We ……..go through the contract carefully before signing it.

12.7 WRITING: FILLING UP AN INVENTORY OF OCCUPATIONAL WORK ETHICS

You have learnt about various desirable qualities that come under work ethics in your reading and listening passages.

Check Your Progress 6

1) Given below are the major heads under work ethics. Complete the inventory.

Work Ethics

i) Interpersonal skills

- ……
- …….
- …….

ii) Initiative

- …….
- …….
- …….

iii) Dependability

- ……..
- ……..
- …….

iv) Positive traditional values

- ……..

- ……..
- ……..
- ……..

v) Positive new values

- …….
- …….
- …….

2) Below is a list of some qualities or skills that are important work ethics in the 21st century. Match them with the correct explanation.

S. No	Qualities/Skills	Explanation
i)	Adaptability	the ability to use one's time effectively
ii)	Cultural competence	the capacity and willingness to organize, develop and manage a business venture
iii)	Imagination	the quality of being able to adjust to new conditions or situations
iv)	Time Management	the ability to successfully exchange or understand information/ideas
v)	Communication	the ability to understand the differences in the background of people and not doing or saying things that might be inappropriate
vi)	Entrepreneurship	the ability to think of new ideas or ways

12.8 LET US SUM UP

Young people are being added to the work force every day. These new recruits need to have some concept of work ethics so that they may be accepted as good workers. It is important to value and respect the code of conduct, work and opinions of others if one wishes to improve one's chances and opportunities for success and growth. In this unit we have empowered you with the language required to deal with this topic.

12.9 ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1) i) Work ethics means morality at work. It includes the right spirit and the right attitude. It makes us responsible and accountable for what we do at the work place.

ii) A person who is good at his/her job, has good relations with colleagues and is honest and reliable is known to have good work ethics.

iii) The three major characteristics of work ethics are interpersonal skills, initiative and dependability.

iv) Yes, our family and immediate environment influence our interpersonal skills. This begins very early in our life. Our attitudes are shaped by our relationships and our early childhood experiences. Some qualities are also inherited.

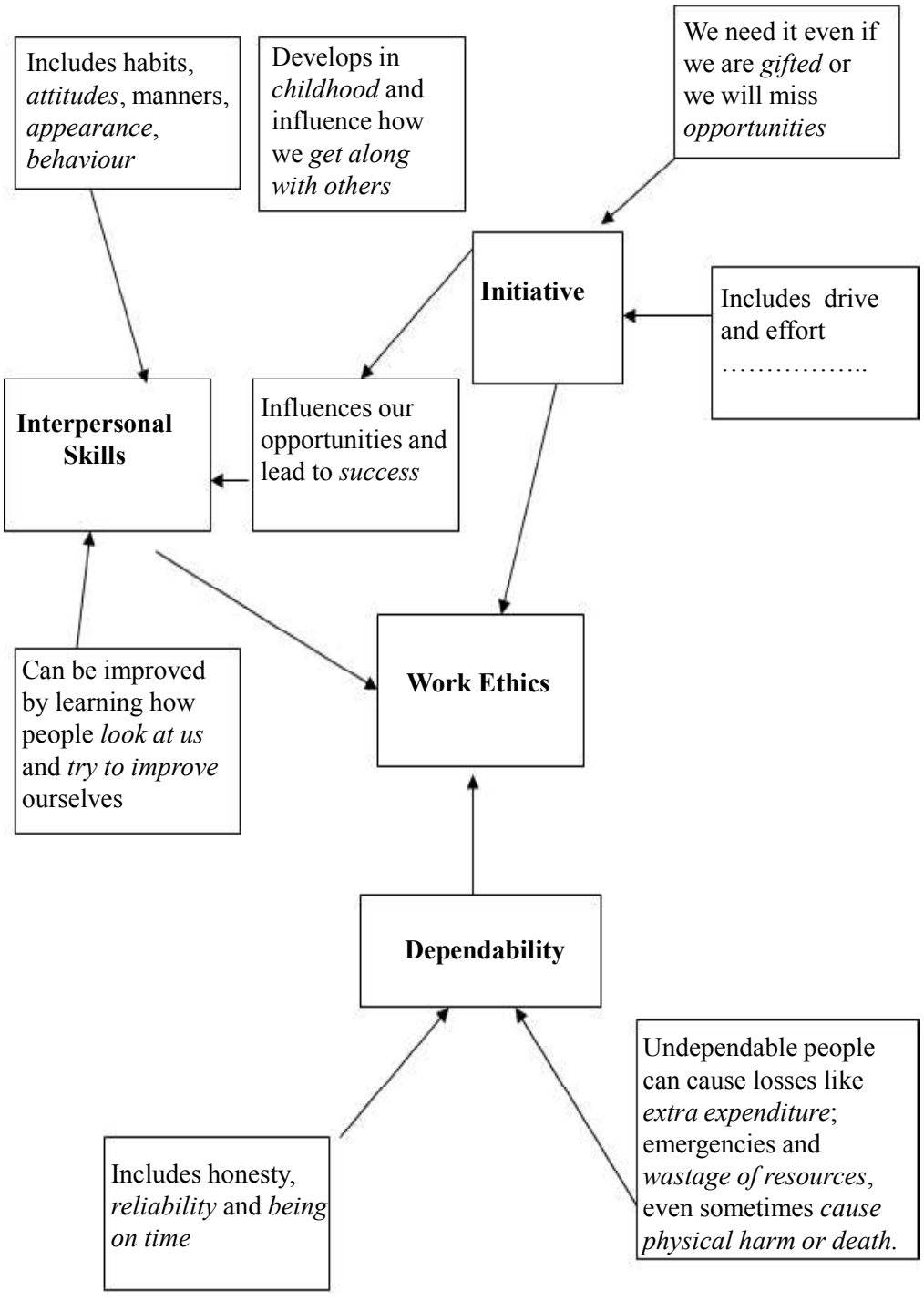
v) Our interpersonal skills affect the way we get along with people. If we have poor interpersonal skills then we would have more conflicts and our functioning will not be smooth.

vi) Often we have habits that we are unaware of. It is a good idea to try to become aware of how others look at us. If we knew that we have any inadequacy we would make a conscious attempt to change ourselves.

vii) In the modern workplace there is no direct supervision and hence we would have to depend on our own drive and initiative to be able to perform well and make the best use of opportunities.

viii) Being gifted is a good thing but this alone is not enough. We need to work harder, better and longer than the others to become the best. Only then we can excel in our field.

2) Completed web chart about 'Work Ethics'.



Check Your Progress 2

i) Rama gets on well with the others in her office. *Good interpersonal skills*

ii) You can give Tamanna any work and you can rest assured that it will be done. *Dependable*

iii) Sameer takes a lot of interest to take on interesting projects and work on them. No one needs to tell him what to do next. *Initiative*

iv) Saloni always comes on time. She is never missing from office. *Punctuality and regularity*

v) Bob always tries to listen to the other person's point of view. Then he gently makes his point. *Right attitude*

vi) Pavan may not be very bright but he works hard and sincerely at whatever job he has at hand. *Hard work and effort*

vii) Ajmal comes very decently and smartly dressed to office. He looks so prim and proper. *Suitable appearance*

viii) We all like the way Tasleen carries herself and interacts with people. She surely makes an impression. *Self-confidence*

Audio text

(Based on a presentation to shareholders of a Europe-based international industrial enterprise, 1999 by Cornelius von Bayer)

I am a management consultant specializing in workplace ethics, what people like to call 'business ethics'. I am now going to talk to you about certain aspects of business ethics.

Between law and religion

I describe my work as filling a middle ground. On the one hand, there is the law, which deals with crime and punishment. On the other, there is religion, which deals with virtue and sin. Organizational ethics sits in between — it goes well beyond the law, and links to the personal beliefs of the employees, but its focus is the corporation or association. Such groups of people must work together to achieve common goals, while also striving to do the right thing in a complex, diverse world.

My brand of organizational ethics actually deals much more with creating and maintaining a healthy corporate culture than with exploring philosophical ethics applied to business.

Codes

Let me describe some of my activities. I help organizations to develop codes of various sorts. Ethic codes generally deal with corporate values and guiding principles, and codes of conduct generally deal with actual behaviour that is favoured or prohibited. However, there is no firm line between different kinds of codes. Codes cover many subjects — each organization needs some but not others at any given time in its history.

Values

Organizational values often include such traditional virtues as trust, loyalty and commitment, honesty and respect for one another, and avoiding conflicts of interest. Values may also include newer elements such as innovation, teamwork, customer focus and continuous improvement.

Check Your Progress 3

1) Completed sentences:
   i) Organizational ethics falls between two things. They are **law and personal beliefs**.
   ii) People in the corporate world need to **work towards a common goal which benefits all.**
   iii) Code of conduct is actually **the behaviour that is favoured or prohibited**.
   iv) Trust, loyalty and commitment are **traditional values**.

Check Your Progress 4

Speech

A very good morning to all my friends here. Today we have gathered here to welcome Mr/Ms…….who has joined us today in the capacity of …… He/she has a lot of experience as a …….in ……company. I am sure we shall find his/her experience and expertise valuable in this organization.

…….. (Name of person) we welcome you to ……. (name of organization). You will be placed in the department of ……/ unit…….

…….. (Name) will be your team leader and your mentor as well. He will help you get used to the working system here and give you guidance as and when necessary. He will help you feel comfortable in your new workplace.

In case you need any other assistance or guidance you are welcome to contact me. I shall certainly find time to discuss any matter with you.

…….. (Name) I am sure the company will grow further with your inputs and your expertise and skills. Friends kindly join us for a cup of tea.

Check Your Progress 5

i) **Need** I carry my certificates for the first informal meeting? I think you **must.** You never know they may like you and would like to know more about you.

ii) We **ought not to** be hasty in coming to conclusions about people.

iii) The employees **must** be at their work stations by 9 o'clock.

iv) I think this matter is serious. You **should** report it to the Director immediately.

v) **Should** he want to see last month's account he can access this file from my folder.

vi) You **need** to get an identity card or a pass made as soon as possible. The gateman will not let you in without it.

vii) I think you **should** stop worrying and concentrate on your new project.

viii) We **must** go through the contract carefully before signing it.

Activity 6

1) Work Ethics

i) Interpersonal skills

- *Right habits and attitude*
- *Pleasing manners and behaviour*
- *Right appearance*

ii) Initiative

- *Self -discipline*
- *Drive*
- *Effort*

iii) Dependability

- *Responsibility*
- *Honesty*
- *Reliability*

iv) Positive traditional values

- *Trust*
- *Loyalty*
- *Commitment*
- *Respect for one another*

v) Positive new values

- *Innovativeness*
- *Team work*
- *Continuous improvement*

2

S. No.	Qualities/Skills
1)	Adaptability: the quality of being able to adjust to new conditions or situations
2)	Cultural competence: the ability to understand the differences in the background of people and not doing or saying things that might be inappropriate
3)	Imagination: the ability to think of new ideas or ways
4)	Time Management: the ability to use one's time effectively
5)	Communication: the ability to successfully exchange or understand information/ideas
6)	Entrepreneurship: the capacity and willingness to organize, develop and manage a business venture